

BEYOND THE KINGDOM — Opening Title Sequence

Document 12 · Locked Canon · Main Titles & Opening Credits (Season 1)

Overview

Item	Detail
Length	About 70 seconds for Episodes #1–#89. About 75 seconds from Episode #90, when Alvin's sequence is added.
Placement	After the Teaser (cold open), before Act One
Theme	"Kingdom (Main Title Theme)." Orchestral strings, a gospel choir humming the melody, a four-note piano motif (<i>the Crown motif</i>), and Atlanta 808 drums underneath. It's old money over a new beat.
Concept	"The Hall of Portraits." The camera glides through the portrait gallery of Donohue Manor, and each gilded frame comes to life.
Who's credited	All adult Contract and Featured Contract Cast
Not credited in opening	Child performers (Emma, Victoria, Lyric), Recurring, Supporting, Day Players, and Guest Stars. They appear in the closing credits , following real daytime practice.
Billing order	Standard group in alphabetical order by performer surname (the real daytime convention, which keeps egos level). Until casting, this document orders by character surname. The five signature sequences always come last, in rising prestige.

Structure of the Sequence

Timecode	Segment	Description
0:00–0:07	Prologue: "Black Water"	Night. The Chattahoochee River runs black beneath the Belmont Crest bluffs. A gold crown shimmers in the water, and a hand's reflection slowly passes over it. The piano plays the Crown motif. The Crown Gate swings open, and the camera passes the scorched pillar and its plaque: " <i>October 24, 1959. We stayed.</i> "
0:07–0:42	The Hall of Portraits (Standard Group)	Inside Donohue Manor's portrait gallery. One continuous dolly move down a corridor of gilded frames. As each frame fills the screen, the painting dissolves into live action (2–3 seconds per actor), then turns back into a painting as the camera moves on.
0:42–1:05	The Signature Sequences	Alvin (from #90), Jasmine, Natasha, Joan, and Victor, each in a unique, fully produced vignette.

Timecode	Segment	Description
1:05–1:12	Main Title	Crane up over Buckhead at night: Donohue Tower and Smiley Tower face each other across Peachtree Road. The two towers' lights reflect in the river. The gold logo BEYOND THE KINGDOM rises between them, crowned. The choir holds the final note.

The Portrait Frame Code (a visual language the fans will decode)

- **Gold frames:** the Donohue family and their blood (the Bullocks and Olsons)
- **Silver frames:** the Smilleys and their circle
- **Bronze frames:** everyone else: friends, law, media
- **Easter egg:** In **Marc-Anthony's** gold frame, the painting's reflection in the glass shows a **black onyx coin** for 6 frames (a quarter-second). Only the sharpest fans on the message boards will catch it.
- **Easter egg:** **Esther's** silver frame has a **gold mask** hanging on the painted wall behind her.

THE STANDARD GROUP — "The Hall of Portraits"

Each credit shows one performer in their character's signature setting, 2–3 seconds long, with the performer's name in white serif lettering on a gold rule. For example: *[Performer] as Marc-Anthony Bullock*.

#	Character	Frame	Live-Action Moment (2–3 sec)	In Titles
1	Amond Baker	Gold	Buttoning his suit jacket in a mirror. His reflection doesn't smile.	#1–180
2	Grace Bullock	Gold	At a studio mic in headphones, belting a note, confetti falling	#1–180
3	Marc-Anthony Bullock	Gold	Laughing with his head thrown back on the Pavilion terrace. Then he turns to camera, and his smile drops for exactly one beat.	#1–180
4	Robert Bullock	Gold	Closing arguments. He slams a folder shut in front of a jury.	#1–180
5	Julian Cross	Bronze	His face half in shadow in a nightclub VIP booth. He touches his jaw as if it doesn't belong to him.	#74–180
6	Arianna Cummings	Bronze	Swearing an oath with her hand on a Bible. Her other hand trembles behind her back.	#1–180
7	Harmony Divine	Bronze	Stapling a "HAVE YOU SEEN DEE?" flyer to a pole, then turning with a SOLD real estate sign	#1–180
8	Simone Donohue	Gold	On the Dowager House porch in a rocking chair, a shotgun across her lap and a teacup in her hand	#1–180
9	Elxa Jackson	Gold	Pinning on her Chief's stars in front of a mirror	#1–180

#	Character	Frame	Live-Action Moment (2–3 sec)	In Titles
10	Jeremy Jackson	Bronze	Under an interrogation-room light, sliding a photo across a table	#1–180
11	Sebastian Kingsley	Silver	Adjusting cufflinks at a London window, then glancing at a ring box	#46–180
12	Mallory Olson	Gold	Spinning in an office chair, then snapping shut a Grace & Glory compact	#1–180
13	Martin Olson	Gold	Lining up a rifle scope at a shooting range. He lowers it and smiles.	#1–180
14	Peter Olson	Gold	Snapping on surgical gloves under operating-room lights	#1–180
15	Desmond Smilley	Silver	Pouring two glasses of cognac and sliding one to someone off-screen	#1–180
16	Esther Smilley	Silver	Walking toward camera in the Smilley Tower lobby, her heels echoing. She stops and removes her sunglasses.	#1–180
17	Lucius Smilley	Silver	Leaning on his silver-headed cane in the Crystal Room. His hand shakes for one frame.	#1–180
18	Luke Smilley	Silver	Tossing a champagne glass into a fireplace	#1–180
19	Odessa Smilley	Silver	At a vintage microphone in a 1940s gown, singing to an empty supper club	#1–180
20	Quentin Smilley	Silver	Behind DJ turntables, crowd lights sweeping. He winks.	#1–180
21	Vivienne Smilley	Silver	Spritzing Smile perfume into the air and stepping through it	#1–180
22	Delphine Smilley-Ashe	Silver	On a Maison Smilley runway, cutting a ribbon with gold scissors	#1–180
23	Celeste Vaughn	Bronze	At the WBKG anchor desk as the ON AIR light flicks on	#1–180

Notes:

- **Julian Cross** is credited under his alias for all of Season 1 to protect the secret on screen. The audience learns he's Vaughn Harlow in Episode #75, but the credit never changes. Fans will argue about it on the message boards.
- **Sebastian Kingsley** joins the titles in Episode #46, his first appearance. **Julian Cross** joins in Episode #74.

THE SIGNATURE SEQUENCES (Unique, 5 seconds each)

These five characters don't appear in the Hall of Portraits. Each gets a **unique, fully produced vignette** with its own **variation of the theme**, and a **billing card** that stays on screen longer. They're billed in rising prestige, and Victor comes last.

1. ALVIN DONOHUE — "The Prince" (added in Episode #90, Monday, May 9, 2005)

- **Music variation:** The theme drops into a **Miami bass / crunk** remix, the only time the titles break genre.
- **Shots:**
 1. Helicopter blades spin over a sunset ocean.
 2. Smash cut to the neon **VELVET** sign flickering on.
 3. Alvin sprays champagne over a VIP crowd in slow motion.
 4. He pulls his sunglasses down, grins at camera, and tosses the bottle to someone off-screen.
- **Final image:** The bottle lands in the hand of an elegant man in shadow. (*Julian Cross. Fans won't notice until July.*)
- **Billing card:** *with* [Performer] as **ALVIN DONOHUE**, in neon-gold script that flickers like a club sign
- **Why it's unique:** Alvin is the only character whose sequence is *loud*. He crashes the elegance of the titles the same way he crashes the family.

2. CONGRESSWOMAN JASMINE DONOHUE OLSON — "The Stateswoman"

- **Music variation:** A brass fanfare (a "Hail to the Chief" feel) over the choir
- **Shots:**
 1. Dawn over the **U.S. Capitol dome**.
 2. Jasmine strides through the **Capitol Rotunda**, her heels echoing, with staffers hurrying behind her.
 3. At the House podium she turns to a wall of camera flashes.
 4. In reverse angle, the flashes become stars on an American flag, which dissolves into the Georgia state flag, and then into a Georgia Governor's Mansion gate that she stops in front of and studies.
- **Billing card:** [Performer] as **CONGRESSWOMAN JASMINE DONOHUE OLSON**, in marble-white lettering carved like a Capitol inscription
- **Why it's unique:** It's the only sequence set outside Atlanta. Her power is national, and the gate at the end foreshadows her run for governor.

3. NATASHA DONOHUE BULLOCK — "The Empress"

- **Music variation:** The full orchestra hits the Crown motif hard, with a snapping percussive beat.
- **Shots:**
 1. The doors of the **DGH boardroom on the 88th floor of Donohue Tower** swing open.
 2. Natasha walks the length of the boardroom table in a white power suit as 30 executives stand.
 3. She drops a ring of **island keys** on the table without stopping.

4. She sits at the head of the table, the Chief Executive's chair, turns to the window, and the whole world skyline is reflected in the glass: Atlanta, London, Paris, Lagos, Tokyo.
 5. She **winks**.
- **Billing card:** *and [Performer] as NATASHA DONOHUE BULLOCK*, with the subtitle *Chief Executive Officer, Donohue Global Holdings* appearing in small caps for one beat
 - **Why it's unique:** It's the only sequence where a character breaks the fourth wall. Natasha bends every rule, including this one.

4. THE HONORABLE JOAN DONOHUE — "The Judge"

- **Music variation:** Solo cello and a single gospel voice carry the Crown motif, the quietest sequence.
- **Shots:**
 1. A black-and-white, 1960s-style shot: young Joan on the steps of a Southern courthouse with a briefcase, facing a hostile crowd.
 2. The shot bleeds into color as a gavel falls in slow motion in a federal courtroom.
 3. In the present day, Joan sits in the Donohue Manor library among law books, removes her reading glasses, and looks up with a small, knowing smile.
 4. Behind her, the photograph of her 1979 swearing-in catches the light.
- **Billing card:** *and [Performer] as THE HONORABLE JOAN DONOHUE*, in gold with a small scale-of-justice emblem
- **Why it's unique:** It's the only sequence that spans 40 years, a lifetime of moral authority in five seconds.

5. VICTOR DONOHUE — "The King" (always last)

- **Music variation:** The entire theme builds to its full crescendo, with orchestra, choir, and drums together.
- **Shots:**
 1. **Dusk**, in Victor's office on the **88th floor of Donohue Tower**. Victor stands at the window with his back to camera and his hands folded behind him.
 2. The camera slowly circles him. On the wall behind him hangs the **portrait of Alexander Donohue**.
 3. He lifts a **black king** from the chess board on his desk and sets it down in the middle of the board with a soft *click*.
 4. As he turns to face the camera, **Smiley Tower's lights switch on across Peachtree** and reflect in his glasses.
 5. He doesn't smile.
- **Billing card:** *and [Performer] as VICTOR DONOHUE*, in engraved gold with the subtitle *Chairman, Donohue Global Holdings*. It holds for a full two seconds, the longest card in the

sequence.

- **Why it's unique:** Victor is the last face before the title, because every other story in the show happens in his kingdom.

TITLE SEQUENCE VERSIONS (Season 1)

Version	Episodes	Airdates	Change	Length
A	#1–#45	Jan 3 – Mar 7, 2005	Premiere version: 21 portraits plus 4 signature sequences	~70 sec
B	#46–#73	Mar 8 – Apr 14, 2005	+ Sebastian Kingsley (portrait)	~70 sec
C	#74–#89	Apr 15 – May 6, 2005	+ Julian Cross (portrait)	~71 sec
D	#90–#180	May 9 – Sep 16, 2005	+ Alvin Donohue (signature sequence)	~75 sec

Final Season 1 opening-credit count:

- **23 portraits** in the Hall of Portraits
- **5 signature sequences:** Alvin, Jasmine, Natasha, Joan, Victor
- **28 credited performers** in total

Special Episode Variations

- **Episode #1 (Premiere):** An extended 90-second version, with an extra aerial shot of the new Smilley Tower's opening morning.
- **Episode #35 (the "New Year's, 2002" flashback special):** The titles play in **black and white**. Arianna's frame is the only one in color.
- **Episode #100 ("Auburn Crown"):** The titles end on the **Hotel Donohue roof in the rain** instead of the two towers.
- **Episode #168 (The Storm):** No music. The Crown motif plays on solo piano over a black screen, with the notice: *"Dedicated to the people of the Gulf Coast."*
- **Episode #180 (Season Finale):** The standard titles play, but the last portrait frame, **Esther's**, cracks.

CLOSING CREDITS (for reference)

- **Format:** A split screen. The episode's final scene freezes on the left while the credits roll on the right over the black-water river.
- **Order:**
 1. **Children:** Emma Smilley, Victoria Smilley, Lyric Solace Baker
 2. **Recurring Cast**

3. **Supporting**
 4. **Day Players**
 5. **"Special Guest Star"** cards, including Theodore, Reginald, and Connie Donohue in Episodes #176–#180
 6. Crew
- **Closing theme:** A 30-second piano-and-choir reprise of "Kingdom."
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SEASON 2 (planned)

- **Theodore, Reginald, and Connie Donohue** join the opening titles when they are promoted to Core Contract Cast. **They join the standard Hall of Portraits unless the creator designates signature sequences for them.**
- Theodore's frame is planned to be the only **black frame** in the gallery.